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12 Rules for Writing Search Queries

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Writing your own search queries to keep tabs on specific cards that you like is a powerful way to customize your Card Ladder experience. It also will make you despise sellers who lazily, inaccurately, and/or deceptively title their listings, causing you endless grief.

Having written tens of thousands of search queries for cards in Card Ladder's verified card database, we've developed rules for writing a good search that you might find helpful.

For further guidance, click the "eBay Buy It Now" button on any card in the Ladder to bring up that card's search query to use as an example.

Here is the final version of a typical Card Ladder search query (which will be broken down into its component parts below):

1986 Fleeer (Stickers,Sticker) Jordan PSA 9 -HGA -CSG -CGC -GMA -SCD -GAI -CEX -FGS -PGI -CSA -KSA -EGS -AGS -BSG -TFA -PGA -AGA -DCS -CGI -ISA -PBI -RCG -SBC -DGA -TGA -WCG -CCG -DSG -VGT -PCA -MGC -CGA -AGC -PGS -FCG -CGS -BGN -DCI -Auto -Autos -Autograph -Autographs -Autographed -Signed -Signature -Signatures -Signing -Signings -DNA -JSA -BAS -COA -Worn -Patch -Patches -Swatch -Swatches -Material -Materials -Relic -Relics -Fabric -Fabrics -Lot -

Lots -Bonus -Extras -Extra -More -Also -Additional -Bundle -Sealed -Unopened -Pick -Choose -Box -Boxes -Reprint -Reprints -Re-Print -Re-Prints -RP -RPs -Reproduction -Reproductions -Repro -Repros -Replica -Counterfeit -Counterfeits -Full -Entire -Complete -Partial -Assorted -MC -MK -OC -PD -Checklists -Checklist -Chklists -Chklist -Chklsts -Chklst -Lists -List -CLs -CL -(PSA 8.5) -(PSA 8) -(PSA 7.5) -(PSA 7) -(PSA 6.5) -(PSA 6) -(PSA 5.5) -(PSA 5) -(PSA 4.5) -(PSA 4) -(PSA 3.5) -(PSA 3) -(PSA 2.5) -(PSA 2) -(PSA 1.5) -(PSA 1) -Illustrated -23kt -23k -24kt -24k -Karat

Note that the rules below are general guidelines, but they aren't perfect. Don't blindly use these rules, but instead customize them to suit the search you're writing.

1. Write the "inclusions" first. Don't be overly specific. Avoid using the card number if you can. In general, use as few words as possible.

Example: **1986 Fleer Sticker Jordan PSA 9**

2. Use parentheses to expand search results. Each time you use multiple terms inside of a parenthetical, it effectively runs a different search for each term.

Example: 1986 Fleer (**Stickers,Sticker**) Jordan PSA 9

3. Use the "-" symbol to write exclusions. Start by removing the names of other grading companies. Sellers sometimes try to rope in views by using the name of a top tier grading company in their listing, even though the card was graded by someone else.

Example: 1986 Fleer (Stickers,Sticker) Jordan PSA 9 **-HGA -CSG -CGC -GMA -SCD -GAI -CEX -FGS -PGI -CSA -KSA -EGS -AGS -BSG -TFA -PGA -AGA -DCS -CGI -ISA -PBI -RCG -SBC -DGA -TGA -WCG -CCG -DSG -VGT -PCA -MGC -CGA -AGC -PGS -FCG -CGS -BGN -DCI**

4. Remove terms that refer to memorabilia (such as an autograph or patch) that isn't featured on the card.

Example: 1986 Fleer (Stickers,Sticker) Jordan PSA 9 -HGA -CSG -CGC -GMA -SCD -GAI -CEX -FGS -PGI -CSA -KSA -EGS -AGS -BSG -TFA -PGA -AGA -DCS -CGI -ISA -PBI -RCG -SBC -DGA -TGA -WCG -CCG -DSG -VGT -PCA -MGC -CGA -AGC -PGS -FCG -CGS -BGN -DCI **-Auto -Autos -Autograph -Autographs -Autographed -Signed -Signature -Signatures -Signing -Signings -**

DNA -JSA -BAS -COA -Worn -Patch -Patches -Swatch -Swatches -Material -Materials -Relic - Relics -Fabric -Fabrics

5. Remove terms that refer to multiple item listings.

Example: 1986 Fleer (Stickers,Sticker) Jordan PSA 9 -HGA -CSG -CGC -GMA -SCD -GAI -CEX - FGS -PGI -CSA -KSA -EGS -AGS -BSG -TFA -PGA -AGA -DCS -CGI -ISA -PBI -RCG -SBC -DGA - TGA -WCG -CCG -DSG -VGT -PCA -MGC -CGA -AGC -PGS -FCG -CGS -BGN -DCI -Auto -Autos - Autograph -Autographs -Autographed -Signed -Signature -Signatures -Signing -Signings -DNA -JSA -BAS -COA -Worn -Patch -Patches -Swatch -Swatches -Material -Materials -Relic -Relics -Fabric - Fabrics **-Lot -Lots -Bonus -Extras -Extra -More -Also -Additional -Bundle**

6. Remove terms that refer to sealed products (such as cases or boxes).

Example: 1986 Fleer (Stickers,Sticker) Jordan PSA 9 -HGA -CSG -CGC -GMA -SCD -GAI -CEX - FGS -PGI -CSA -KSA -EGS -AGS -BSG -TFA -PGA -AGA -DCS -CGI -ISA -PBI -RCG -SBC -DGA - TGA -WCG -CCG -DSG -VGT -PCA -MGC -CGA -AGC -PGS -FCG -CGS -BGN -DCI -Auto -Autos - Autograph -Autographs -Autographed -Signed -Signature -Signatures -Signing -Signings -DNA -JSA -BAS -COA -Worn -Patch -Patches -Swatch -Swatches -Material -Materials -Relic -Relics -Fabric - Fabrics -Lot -Lots -Bonus -Extras -Extra -More -Also -Additional -Bundle **-Sealed -Unopened -Pick - Choose -Box -Boxes**

7. Remove terms that refer to reprints.

Example: 1986 Fleer (Stickers,Sticker) Jordan PSA 9 -HGA -CSG -CGC -GMA -SCD -GAI -CEX - FGS -PGI -CSA -KSA -EGS -AGS -BSG -TFA -PGA -AGA -DCS -CGI -ISA -PBI -RCG -SBC -DGA - TGA -WCG -CCG -DSG -VGT -PCA -MGC -CGA -AGC -PGS -FCG -CGS -BGN -DCI -Auto -Autos - Autograph -Autographs -Autographed -Signed -Signature -Signatures -Signing -Signings -DNA -JSA -BAS -COA -Worn -Patch -Patches -Swatch -Swatches -Material -Materials -Relic -Relics -Fabric - Fabrics -Lot -Lots -Bonus -Extras -Extra -More -Also -Additional -Bundle -Sealed -Unopened -Pick - Choose -Box -Boxes **-Reprint -Reprints -Re-Print -Re-Prints -RP -RPs -Reproduction - Reproductions -Repro -Repros -Replica -Counterfeit -Counterfeits**

8. Remove terms that refer to complete set listings.

Example: 1986 Fleer (Stickers,Sticker) Jordan PSA 9 -HGA -CSG -CGC -GMA -SCD -GAI -CEX - FGS -PGI -CSA -KSA -EGS -AGS -BSG -TFA -PGA -AGA -DCS -CGI -ISA -PBI -RCG -SBC -DGA -

TGA -WCG -CCG -DSG -VGT -PCA -MGC -CGA -AGC -PGS -FCG -CGS -BGN -DCI -Auto -Autos - Autograph -Autographs -Autographed -Signed -Signature -Signatures -Signing -Signings -DNA -JSA -BAS -COA -Worn -Patch -Patches -Swatch -Swatches -Material -Materials -Relic -Relics -Fabric - Fabrics -Lot -Lots -Bonus -Extras -Extra -More -Also -Additional -Bundle -Sealed -Unopened -Pick - Choose -Box -Boxes -Reprint -Reprints -Re-Print -Re-Prints -RP -RPs -Reproduction -Reproductions -Repro -Repros -Replica -Counterfeit -Counterfeits -**Full -Entire -Complete -Partial -Assorted**

9. Remove terms that refer to checklists (unless, of course, the card you're searching is a checklist).

Example: 1986 Fleer (Stickers,Sticker) Jordan PSA 9 -HGA -CSG -CGC -GMA -SCD -GAI -CEX - FGS -PGI -CSA -KSA -EGS -AGS -BSG -TFA -PGA -AGA -DCS -CGI -ISA -PBI -RCG -SBC -DGA - TGA -WCG -CCG -DSG -VGT -PCA -MGC -CGA -AGC -PGS -FCG -CGS -BGN -DCI -Auto -Autos - Autograph -Autographs -Autographed -Signed -Signature -Signatures -Signing -Signings -DNA -JSA -BAS -COA -Worn -Patch -Patches -Swatch -Swatches -Material -Materials -Relic -Relics -Fabric - Fabrics -Lot -Lots -Bonus -Extras -Extra -More -Also -Additional -Bundle -Sealed -Unopened -Pick - Choose -Box -Boxes -Reprint -Reprints -Re-Print -Re-Prints -RP -RPs -Reproduction -Reproductions -Repro -Repros -Replica -Counterfeit -Counterfeits -Full -Entire -Complete -Partial -**MC -MK -OC - PD**

10. Remove qualifiers (unless you're seeking a card with a qualifier).

Example: 1986 Fleer (Stickers,Sticker) Jordan PSA 9 -HGA -CSG -CGC -GMA -SCD -GAI -CEX - FGS -PGI -CSA -KSA -EGS -AGS -BSG -TFA -PGA -AGA -DCS -CGI -ISA -PBI -RCG -SBC -DGA - TGA -WCG -CCG -DSG -VGT -PCA -MGC -CGA -AGC -PGS -FCG -CGS -BGN -DCI -Auto -Autos - Autograph -Autographs -Autographed -Signed -Signature -Signatures -Signing -Signings -DNA -JSA -BAS -COA -Worn -Patch -Patches -Swatch -Swatches -Material -Materials -Relic -Relics -Fabric - Fabrics -Lot -Lots -Bonus -Extras -Extra -More -Also -Additional -Bundle -Sealed -Unopened -Pick - Choose -Box -Boxes -Reprint -Reprints -Re-Print -Re-Prints -RP -RPs -Reproduction -Reproductions -Repro -Repros -Replica -Counterfeit -Counterfeits -Full -Entire -Complete -Partial -Assorted -MC - MK -OC -PD -**Checklists -Checklist -Chklists -Chklist -Chklsts -Chklst -Lists -List -CLs -CL**

11. Remove terms that refer to other grades. Using parentheses in an exclusion removes *only* the exact phrase, including spaces, inside the parentheses.

Example: 1986 Fleer (Stickers,Sticker) Jordan PSA 9 -HGA -CSG -CGC -GMA -SCD -GAI -CEX - FGS -PGI -CSA -KSA -EGS -AGS -BSG -TFA -PGA -AGA -DCS -CGI -ISA -PBI -RCG -SBC -DGA - TGA -WCG -CCG -DSG -VGT -PCA -MGC -CGA -AGC -PGS -FCG -CGS -BGN -DCI -Auto -Autos - Autograph -Autographs -Autographed -Signed -Signature -Signatures -Signing -Signings -DNA -JSA

-BAS -COA -Worn -Patch -Patches -Swatch -Swatches -Material -Materials -Relic -Relics -Fabric - Fabrics -Lot -Lots -Bonus -Extras -Extra -More -Also -Additional -Bundle -Sealed -Unopened -Pick - Choose -Box -Boxes -Reprint -Reprints -Re-Print -Re-Prints -RP -RPs -Reproduction -Reproductions -Repro -Repros -Replica -Counterfeit -Counterfeits -Full -Entire -Complete -Partial -Assorted -MC - MK -OC -PD -Checklists -Checklist -Chklists -Chklist -Chklsts -Chklst -Lists -List -CLs -CL -(PSA 8.5) -(PSA 8) -(PSA 7.5) -(PSA 7) -(PSA 6.5) -(PSA 6) -(PSA 5.5) -(PSA 5) -(PSA 4.5) -(PSA 4) -(PSA 3.5) -(PSA 3) -(PSA 2.5) -(PSA 2) -(PSA 1.5) -(PSA 1)

12. Remove any other terms that bring in undesired results, such as the name of parallels or variations. Note that ultra modern cards with dozens of parallels will have lengthy exclusions lists.

Example: 1986 Fleer (Stickers,Sticker) Jordan PSA 9 -HGA -CSG -CGC -GMA -SCD -GAI -CEX - FGS -PGI -CSA -KSA -EGS -AGS -BSG -TFA -PGA -AGA -DCS -CGI -ISA -PBI -RCG -SBC -DGA - TGA -WCG -CCG -DSG -VGT -PCA -MGC -CGA -AGC -PGS -FCG -CGS -BGN -DCI -Auto -Autos - Autograph -Autographs -Autographed -Signed -Signature -Signatures -Signing -Signings -DNA -JSA -BAS -COA -Worn -Patch -Patches -Swatch -Swatches -Material -Materials -Relic -Relics -Fabric - Fabrics -Lot -Lots -Bonus -Extras -Extra -More -Also -Additional -Bundle -Sealed -Unopened -Pick - Choose -Box -Boxes -Reprint -Reprints -Re-Print -Re-Prints -RP -RPs -Reproduction -Reproductions -Repro -Repros -Replica -Counterfeit -Counterfeits -Full -Entire -Complete -Partial -Assorted -MC - MK -OC -PD -Checklists -Checklist -Chklists -Chklist -Chklsts -Chklst -Lists -List -CLs -CL -(PSA 8.5) -(PSA 8) -(PSA 7.5) -(PSA 7) -(PSA 6.5) -(PSA 6) -(PSA 5.5) -(PSA 5) -(PSA 4.5) -(PSA 4) -(PSA 3.5) -(PSA 3) -(PSA 2.5) -(PSA 2) -(PSA 1.5) -(PSA 1) **-Illustrated -23kt -23k -24kt -24k -Karat -57 - Merchante -PRO**

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